

# Practice

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## Abstract

Practice is not repetition. Repetition without resistance produces fluency, not skill. Practice is the repeated encounter with the thing that does not yield until you find the adjustment that works and build into the body the capacity to make it again.

The musician who practices is not playing the piece over and over. She is finding, over and over, where she is not yet adequate to the piece.

The note she keeps missing is not a mistake to correct. It is the location of the next adjustment. Practice is the process of locating what is not yet in the body and putting it there.

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This is why practice cannot be shortened.

The adjustment must be made by the body. The body takes time to update. There is no acceleration. A muscle memory that took ten years cannot be transferred in a week. The transfer requires the encounters. The encounters require the time.

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AI does not practice. It trains. Training and practice look similar from outside. They are not the same.

Training is exposure to examples. The gradient updates weights. The weights are what change.

Practice is encounter with resistance. The adjustment updates the body. The body is what changes.

A body that has changed through practice knows the piece differently than a network that has been trained on recordings of the piece.

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The recording captures what was played. It does not capture what was missed on the way to playing it.

What was missed is the practice. The practice is not in the recording. It is in the musician.

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The mathematician practicing at the wall is not reviewing proofs. She is attempting the thing that does not work and finding, in the failure, the shape of the obstruction.

After enough failures the obstruction has a shape. The shape is not in any paper. It is in her. It is available to her in future encounters because her attention was trained on this obstruction across these specific failures.

No one else's failures transfer this. Reading the papers does not transfer this. The shape must be found by the practitioner in her own failures.

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Practice is private in this sense: it cannot be substituted.

You can watch someone practice. You can read what they wrote about practicing. You cannot practice for them. You cannot accelerate their acquisition.

This is not a limitation of current tools. It is the structure of the thing. Skill is acquired through encounter. Encounter is not transferable. The body that encounters is singular.

## References

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